

What 736 Performances Reveal About Choral Programming in 2025–26

A first look at repertoire trends from a season of shared concert programs

By Rick Retzko

Choral directors make dozens of programming decisions at least twice a year — how to open the next concert, which arranger's "Veni, Veni" to use (Trotta!), whether this is finally the year to program that Ešenvalds octavo sitting in the folder. Multiply those decisions across even a few dozen programs and certain patterns begin to emerge: which composers are being sung, not just anthologized; which arrangers quietly dominate a season; and whether the field is moving in any specific direction.

This article is a first attempt to look at those patterns directly, using data from ChoirTrends.com, a platform where directors upload their concert programs — repertoire, ensembles, dates, and schools — as they build each season. From September 2025 through July 2026, choral directors logged 63 concert programs from 40 schools, totaling 736 individual performances of 694 unique titles.

A note on the data, up front. This is a small, self-selected sample — early users of one platform, concentrated in New Jersey (40 of 63 programs), with smaller representation from Rhode Island, New York, Pennsylvania, Wisconsin, Maryland, and Tennessee, plus a first international data point from two schools in Trier, Germany. This was not a scientific survey of American choral programming but instead a real, unfiltered look at actual concert programs as directors shared them — no anthologizing, no self-reporting bias toward "important" repertoire, just what actually was performed. As the dataset grows in future seasons, we expect these patterns to sharpen; for now, treat what follows as a signal worth watching rather than a settled conclusion.

METHODOLOGY

Data drawn from ChoirTrends concert program logs, September 1, 2025–July 31, 2026. Figures include only performances with a matching program and event date in range; composer/arranger figures require an attributed composer or arranger on the song title record. "Trend" threshold set at 3+ performances per the platform's standard reporting convention. Full query detail available on request.

Living composers, not historical ones, dominate the season. Outside the December repertoire, the most-programmed composers were overwhelmingly living composers working today: Elaine Hagenberg, Ola Gjeilo, Jennifer Lucy Cook, and Eric Whitacre all appeared in the season's top tier, all composing from within the last decade. The only

composer from an earlier era to break into the top five — George Frideric Handel — owed his position almost entirely to holiday programming. This tracks with a broader shift many directors have felt anecdotally: that today's active repertoire pipeline is increasingly built around living voices, not the historical canon, except where the calendar itself calls for tradition.

A distinct Nordic/Baltic sound runs through the season. One of the clearest stylistic threads in the data is a cluster of composers writing spacious, atmospheric, text-centered choral music from the Nordic and Baltic countries: Ola Gjeilo (Norway), Pärt Uusberg (Estonia), and Ešēnvalds (Latvia). Gjeilo alone was performed 8 times across 7 different programs — trailing only Elaine Hagenberg and generic "Traditional/anonymous" attributions among all composers in the dataset — with "Tundra" appearing three times on its own. Uusberg and Ešēnvalds each appeared 3 times across 3 programs, clearing the "trend" threshold on a much smaller total sample size than Gjeilo. Taken together, this Nordic/Baltic aesthetic was present in roughly one in ten logged programs — notable given that none of these composers write primarily in English or draw on American choral tradition. It's a pattern consistent with what several state ACDA reading sessions have highlighted in recent years, which translates into actual programming, not just conference buzz.

One piece stood out above the rest. "Time," by Jennifer Lucy Cook, was the most-performed single title in the dataset — 7 performances, all but two of them in the spring semester. No other title came close during spring; the next tier ("Tundra" by Ola Gjeilo, "Glow" by Eric Whitacre, "Veni, Veni Emmanuel" by Michael John Trotta, "Muusika" by Pärt Uusberg, and "O Love" by Elaine Hagenberg) each landed 3 performances across the full year. What's more striking than any single title, though, is how rare repeats were at all: of 736 total selections, only 42 included a title performed more than once anywhere in the dataset. Directors, at least in this sample, are not reaching for the same shelf.

Winter and spring tell different stories. Splitting the season in two reveals a clear seasonal divide. Winter programming (September through January, 24 concerts) leaned sacred and seasonal — Handel, Byrd, Victoria, and Vivaldi appeared alongside Gjeilo's wintry soundscapes and Trotta's "Veni, Veni Emmanuel." On the arranging side, Roger Emerson was the dominant voice of the winter season by a wide margin: 10 performances across 7 programs, nearly double the next most-used arranger. Spring programming (February through July, 39 concerts) shifted decisively toward contemporary American voices — Hagenberg, Cook, Pederson, Rollo Dilworth, and Marta Keen led the composer list, while the arranger landscape broadened considerably, with Mark Brymer, Kirby Shaw, Craig Hella Johnson, and Audrey Snyder all posting strong numbers. Pop crossover repertoire also surfaced in spring with arrangements of "Dust in the Wind" and "Homeward Bound" appearing multiple times. This suggests some directors are deliberately bridging choral and popular repertoire for spring audiences in a way that doesn't show up in winter programming at all.

What we don't yet know. Ensemble-level detail — whether a piece was sung by an SATB choir, an SSA/treble ensemble, a TTBB group, or performed a cappella — was only reliably recorded for about 23% of performances in this dataset; the rest are logged simply as "Unknown" ensemble type. Where we do have that detail, some patterns emerge (SATB choirs accounted for the largest typed share, and a cappella performances were concentrated there as well), but with this much missing data, we're not treating the ensemble-type breakdown as reliable yet — it's included for context, not as a finding.

Where this goes next. This is a first snapshot from a single season and a still-small, geographically concentrated dataset. The value of this kind of analysis compounds with scale: as more directors upload more programs, patterns like the Nordic/Baltic thread, the winter/spring arranger divide, and shifts in the historical-versus-contemporary balance will become sharper and more defensible. We'll be revisiting this analysis with a hopefully larger, more geographically diverse sample as we welcome any choral director's data to be included as part of the bigger picture.

WHAT ELSE WILL YOU FIND?

While this article focuses on a single season of submissions, ChoirTrends.com now contains more than 20 years of archived concert programs from New Jersey All-State Mixed Chorus. As the database continues to grow, it will offer an increasingly valuable resource for studying repertoire programming, historical trends, and evolving practices in choral music education. If you are the keeper of the same archival programs for your state, please consider adding those programs to ChoirTrends.com.

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ChoirTrends.com is a free, online resource offered as a gift to the choral community, requiring the commitment to upload at least two choral programs per year.

TheDirectorsRoom.com streamlines the administration of auditioned regional and state honors choirs with integrated registration and online adjudication.